

abilities, or at least your willingness to learn any new skills needed to execute your plans.

You might be happy to update the paint, landscaping, and appliances but not be willing to commit to any major projects that involve a contractor (like moving walls, repairing the foundation, updating the electrical service, fixing the roof, or any other high-ticket items). Maybe you're fine replacing the floors, but you don't want to deal with windows. Just make sure you know your limitations so you can avoid those items should they come up.

Do you want to live in an HOA community?

Ah, the homeowner's association. Some people love HOAs and some people hate them. Why? Rules. Lots and lots of rules. Some help keep the neighborhood looking good—so no overlong grass, no weeds, and no broken-down cars in your neighbor's front yard. Some seem overly restrictive, like limiting the number of cars that can be parked in your driveway, your ability to rent out the house should your circumstances change (did someone say *exit option*?), and even limiting the size and type of pets you're allowed to have.

These neighborhoods are also called covenant-controlled communities. They can provide order to a neighborhood and enforce uniformity, and they charge a fee for all this. Your HOA dues are used to maintain any common areas, and while they start around \$100 per month, they can climb dramatically depending on the area and the amenities. A neighborhood with a pool, tennis courts, basketball courts, meeting space, playgrounds, and large open spaces that provides trash and snow removal and landscaping can easily reach \$1,000 per month in HOA fees. This fee doesn't pay a cent toward your mortgage but is still coming out of your pocket every month. If you are interested in HOA homes, make sure you factor this cost into your monthly budget.

Whether or not you want to live in an HOA community depends entirely on personal preference. If you don't want an HOA telling you what you can do with your property—like the type of plants you're allowed to put in your yard, the color you can paint your home's exterior, and so on—make sure you're not buying in a covenant-controlled neighborhood. On the other hand, if you want the neighborhood structure that comes along with the